

Night flights at Bournemouth Airport

The rules, what is actually happening over the village, and how Bournemouth's night regime compares with other UK airports.
Working note for the group.

Night quota period 23:30–06:00 · figures verified against official sources

1 The rules at Bournemouth

- **Night period: 23:30 to 06:00** (the official "night quota period", as defined in the 2007 Section 106 agreement and Noise Action Plan).
- **Night noise budget: 3,100 Quota Count (QC) points per year**, set in 2007 and unchanged since. QC is a noise score, so this caps total night *noise*, not the number of flights.
- **There is no cap on the number of night flights.** This is unusual: most comparable airports also limit how many aircraft may operate at night.
- The noisiest aircraft are restricted: QC8 and QC16 are banned at night, and QC4 cannot be scheduled.
- The airport uses only a fraction of the budget today. But its own Noise Action Plan states that **"the same points total can be maintained by operating a greater [number of aircraft]"** as jets get quieter, so a fixed budget allows ever more flights over time. At QC0.5 for a typical 737 landing, 3,100 points is roughly **6,200 landings a year (about 17 a night)**, and rising.

2 What is actually happening (our flight data, 2023–2025)

+95%

Night arrivals over 23:30–06:00

251 (2023) → 490 (2025), almost doubled

+158%

Large jets arriving at night

159 (2023) → 411 (2025), more than doubled

+28%

All movements, 2026 so far

CAA official, Jan–May vs 2025

Actual aircraft counted from their own GPS (ADS-B) broadcasts, using the airport's official 23:30–06:00 night window. Independently cross-checked as 99.9% complete against the CAA's official movement figures. These are real flights, separate from the noise-points budget above.

3 How Bournemouth compares

Airport	Size (approx)	Cap on number of night flights?	Night noise quota (QC pts/yr)	Source
Bournemouth	~1.4m pax	None	3,100	Noise Action Plan 2024
Southampton	~1m pax	~100 / year (medical, technical, delays only)	near-curfew	Aircraft noise
Bristol	~10m pax	4,000 / year	QC4+ not scheduled	Night flying
Exeter	~0.5m pax	None	None (nightly Royal Mail)	Movements & noise
Heathrow	~80m pax	~5,800 / year	5,150 (2,415 W + 2,735 S)	Night flights
Gatwick	~40m pax	~14,450 / year	6,935 (1,785 W + 5,150 S)	DfT decision 2025
Stansted	~28m pax	~13,700 / year	7,960 (3,310 W + 4,650 S)	DfT decision 2025

London airports (Heathrow/Gatwick/Stansted) quota figures are the current Government-set limits (regime Oct 2025 – Oct 2028), and apply *alongside* a movement cap. Systems differ between airports, so each is shown on its own terms.

- **Bournemouth is one of the few UK airports with no limit on the number of night flights** – only a noise budget. Bristol caps at 4,000 a year, Southampton at about 100, and even the big London airports cap movements as well as noise.
- **The noise budget is generous for the airport's size.** At 3,100 points it is about 60% of Heathrow's and 40–45% of Gatwick's and Stansted's, despite Bournemouth handling a tiny fraction of their traffic.
- **Our nearest neighbour is far stricter.** Southampton, similar size and same region, permits only about 100 night movements a year, and tightened its rules under community pressure.
- **Night flights are already climbing fast and the budget will not stop them:** night arrivals have almost doubled and large jets at night have more than doubled since 2023, only a fraction of the budget is used, and quieter aircraft let the same budget carry ever more flights.